▼ GLASSHOUSE



BEND IT LIKE BICHARPUR

Chief ministers visiting foreign locales are often chasing investments for their states, but Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav had a rather more unusual pit stop on his trip to Spain. He dropped by La Liga headquarters, home of the Spanish football league, and invited them to invest in MP's sports infrastructure and train the local youth. This raised more than a few eyebrows, of course, since MP barely registers on the football map of India. The answer may well lie in Bicharpur, a village near tribal-dominated Shahdol, whose football chops led PM Narendra Modi to dub it a "mini Brazil" in one of his *Mann ki Baat* episodes. Yadav may not be able to tell offside in football, but he sure does know who mans the goalposts.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ SECULAR TURN

DEVOTION OR DESIGN?

Kairana MP **Iqra Hasan** has got the right wing in a tizzy in Uttar Pradesh. Some time ago, the Samajwadi Party leader had slammed the Meerut police's move to ban roadside namaaz, saying they were trying to create a "chasm of hate in society".



Last week, however, Iqra donned a different avatar, draped in a saffron scarf and distributing prasad to the kanwariyas. The visuals went viral, earning both kudos and confusion. Outreach or optics? Symbolism or just solid constituency work? One thing is clear: Iqra Hasan isn't playing by any known script.